The State of Web Accessibility in European E-commerce 2026

An automated WCAG 2.2 AA benchmark of 45 major online shops in Germany, France and the Netherlands, one year after the European Accessibility Act came into force.

82%
of homepages fail at least one automated WCAG 2.2 A/AA check

47%
have at least one **critical** barrier that can block users completely

2.2
distinct WCAG issues per homepage on average

Key findings

• The most common barrier, **elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds**, appears on 47% of homepages.
• Next come **all touch targets must be 24px large, or leave sufficient space** (29%) and **links must have discernible text** (27%).
• Most issues are template-level: fixing them once in the shop theme fixes every page that uses it.

Top 10 barriers

#	Barrier (axe-core rule)	Share of homepages
1	Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds color-contrast	**47%**
2	All touch targets must be 24px large, or leave sufficient space target-size	**29%**
3	Links must have discernible text link-name	**27%**
4	Images must have alternative text image-alt	**20%**
5	Buttons must have discernible text button-name	**16%**
6	and must only directly contain , <script> or <template> elements list	**13%**
7	Zooming and scaling must not be disabled meta-viewport	**9%**
8	ARIA dialog and alertdialog nodes should have an accessible name aria-dialog-name	**7%**
9	Interactive controls must not be nested nested-interactive	**7%**
10	Elements must only use supported ARIA attributes aria-allowed-attr	**7%**

By country

Country	Homepages tested	Fail ≥1 WCAG check	Avg. distinct issues
Germany	19	84%	1.9
France	9	89%	2.6
Netherlands	17	76%	2.2

Country samples are small, so differences between countries are indicative only.

Methodology

We selected 99 large consumer e-commerce sites (about a third per country) and tested each homepage once in Google Chrome with axe-core 4.10 against WCAG 2.0/2.1/2.2 A and AA rules. 54 sites could not be tested (bot protection or timeouts) and are excluded. Only rules mapped to WCAG success criteria are counted, not best-practice rules. Automated tools detect roughly a third of all WCAG issues, so these figures are a lower bound. Results describe the homepage on the test date (24 October 2026) and are not a legal conformance assessment. Individual site results are not published.

What shop owners should do now

1. Run a full audit including checkout and manual keyboard / screen-reader testing.
2. Fix template-level issues first: they remove the most barriers per hour of work.
3. Publish an accessibility statement and re-test monthly, since new products and theme updates re-introduce issues.

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